

AP Comparative Government & Politics: The Complete Exam Guide

The 5 units and 6 core countries explained, the four free-response question types, a comparison playbook, and 10 hard practice questions.

Hi, I'm **Pigo!** I'll drop tips all through this guide.

**2:30**

hours total
60 + 90 minutes

55+4

multiple-choice +
free-response questions

6 countries

studied in depth

70–72%

scored 3 or higher
in recent years

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01 THE EXAM AT A GLANCE

Two sections, one score

Your AP score (1–5) combines a multiple-choice section and a free-response section, each worth half. Everything is about comparing how six countries are governed.

50%

Section I · Multiple choice · 55 questions

50%

Section II · Free response · 4 questions

Exam structure

Section	Weight & timing	What you do
I · Multiple choice	50% of score 1 hour 55 questions	Questions on concepts and the six core countries, including sets built on data, maps and text passages.
II · Free response	50% of score 1 hr 30 min 4 questions	Conceptual analysis · Quantitative analysis · Comparative analysis · Argument essay. Each is worth 11–14% of the exam score.

FULLY DIGITAL

Everything happens in Bluebook

You answer every question, including the written responses, in College Board's **Bluebook** testing app. Responses are submitted automatically at the end. Practice typing timed answers before May.

THE CORE COUNTRIES

China, Iran, Mexico, Nigeria, Russia, UK

Every question draws on these **six countries**. They range from democracies to authoritarian regimes, so you can compare institutions, elections and policies across systems.

How to use this guide

Just starting?

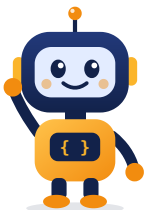
Read pages 2–6, then follow the roadmap on page 8 month by month.

Mid-year?

Check the traps on page 7 and drill the free-response playbook on page 6.

Exam in weeks?

Take the 10 questions on page 9 in 13 minutes, then use the final-four-weeks plan.



Pigo's tip: Make a **country comparison grid**: rows for each concept (executive, legislature, elections, parties, civil society), columns for the six countries.

SECTION I

02 The multiple-choice section

55 questions in 60 minutes gives you just over 1 minute per question.
Knowing country facts well is what makes this pace possible.

55

questions on concepts
and countries

~1:05

minutes per question on
average

50%

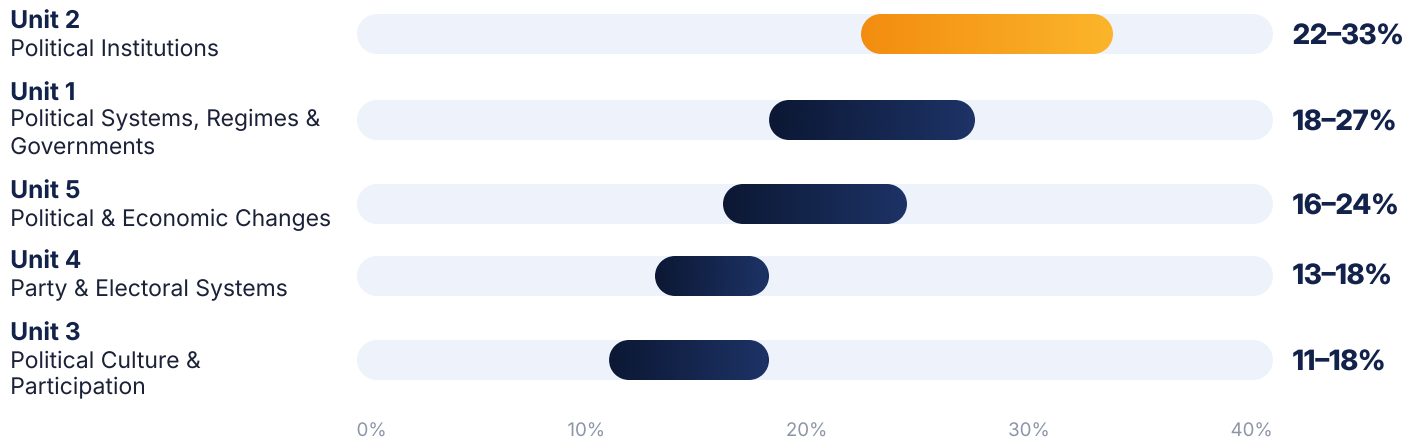
of your total AP score

0

points lost for a wrong
answer, so never leave
one blank

How the questions are weighted by unit

College Board gives a range for each unit's share of the exam. Bars show minimum to maximum.

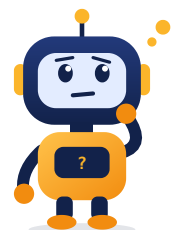


What this means for your study time: Political institutions (executives, legislatures, courts) are the biggest unit. Learn how each of the six countries organizes its institutions first.

Strategies that work on this section

- **Know the vocabulary precisely:** legitimacy, sovereignty, authority, power, state, nation, regime.
- **Classify each country** as democratic, hybrid or authoritarian, and be ready to explain why.
- **Read charts as evidence** for a claim. Look at the axes and the time period first.
- **Compare systems:** presidential, parliamentary and semi-presidential; single-member districts and proportional representation.
- **Eliminate answers about the wrong country.** Many wrong choices are true of a different country.
- **Flag and move on** after 90 seconds.

A wrong choice is often **true for another country**. Check which country the question is about!



03 WHAT THE COURSE COVERS

The 5 units, in plain English

Everything on the exam fits into these five units, always applied to the six core countries.

UNIT

1

18–27%

Political Systems, Regimes & Governments

What kind of state each country is.

Be ready to: compare democratic and authoritarian regimes; explain sources of legitimacy and stability; describe federal and unitary systems; measure democracy with indicators.

UNIT

2

22–33%

Political Institutions

Executives, legislatures and courts.

Be ready to: compare presidential, parliamentary and semi-presidential systems; explain term limits and removal; describe legislative independence; compare judicial independence and review.

UNIT

3

11–18%

Political Culture & Participation

How citizens relate to government.

Be ready to: explain political socialization and ideology; compare civil rights and liberties; analyze social movements and how governments respond to cleavages.

UNIT

4

13–18%

Party & Electoral Systems & Citizen Organizations

Elections, parties and interest groups.

Be ready to: compare single-member district and proportional representation systems; explain party systems; describe pluralist and corporatist interest groups.

UNIT

5

16–24%

Political & Economic Changes & Development

How globalization and policy reshape states.

Be ready to: explain economic liberalization, privatization and globalization; analyze responses to economic change, social policy and environmental challenges.

◆ The six core countries at a glance

Country	System	Key features to know
United Kingdom	Parliamentary democracy, unitary	Prime minister from the majority party; uncodified constitution; devolution to Scotland, Wales and Northern Ireland.
Mexico	Presidential democracy, federal	Single six-year presidential term; transition from one-party PRI rule to multiparty competition.
Nigeria	Presidential democracy, federal	Ethnic and religious cleavages; history of military rule; oil-dependent economy.
Russia	Semi-presidential, authoritarian	Strong presidency; dominant party; limited media freedom and civil society.
China	One-party communist state	Chinese Communist Party controls the state; economic reform since 1978; limited political rights.
Iran	Theocratic republic	Supreme Leader holds ultimate authority; elected president and parliament; Guardian Council vets candidates.

SECTION II

04 The 4 free-response questions

90 minutes, 4 questions worth 11–14% each. The four question types are the same every year.

Q1 • Concept

Q2 • Data

Q3 • Compare

Q4 • Argument

Q1 11% • Q2 12.5% • Q3 12.5% • Q4 14% of your AP score

Q1

Conceptual analysis

~10 minutes

Define or describe a political concept, then explain it and apply it to a situation.

Definitions must be precise; the rest of the answer builds on them.

Q2

Quantitative analysis

~20 minutes

Describe data from a chart or table, identify a pattern, and draw a conclusion linked to a political concept.

Use exact numbers and compare at least two data points.

Q3

Comparative analysis

~20 minutes

Compare how two of the six countries handle a concept, explaining a similarity or difference and its effect.

Give a specific fact for each country, not a general claim.

Q4

Argument essay

~40 minutes

Build an argument with a claim, two pieces of evidence from course countries, reasoning, and a response to an opposing view.

Choose the side you can support with the most specific country evidence.

♦ A time plan for the 90 minutes

Q1

~10 min

Q2

~20 min

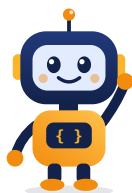
Q3

~20 min

Q4

~40 min

A suggested split, not a rule. Start with the question type you're strongest at, and never leave a question blank.



In comparisons, write "**whereas**" sentences: "The UK has a fused executive, whereas Mexico..."

05

FREE-RESPONSE PLAYBOOK

Anatomy of a strong argument

The argument essay follows a fixed rubric. Here is a practice prompt with a strong response, annotated.

PRACTICE TASK • WRITTEN BY ACT SAT GO

Practice prompt (Q4 style): Develop an argument about whether proportional representation or single-member district systems better promote government accountability. Use one or more course countries as evidence.

Sample argument (condensed)

① **Thesis:** Single-member district systems better promote accountability because voters can identify and remove the representative and the governing party responsible for outcomes.

② In the United Kingdom, first-past-the-post elections usually produce a single-party majority, so voters know which party to reward or punish at the next election.

③ Each MP represents a specific constituency, so constituents can hold an individual representative responsible.

④ Supporters of proportional representation argue it is fairer to small parties. However, the coalition governments it often produces blur responsibility, making it harder for voters to know whom to blame.

- ① **Thesis** with a defensible claim and reasoning.
- ② **Evidence** from a specific course country.
- ③ **Reasoning** that explains why the evidence supports the claim.
- ④ **Response to an opposing view**, with a refutation.

Five habits for every free-response question

1

Answer each lettered part separately and in order.

2

Define concepts precisely before applying them.

3

Use a specific fact for every country you name.

4

Quote numbers from charts and compare them.

5

Stuck? Define the concept; it can still earn a point.

06 LEARN FROM OTHERS

10 traps that cost points

Meet **Glitch**. He lives in these ten mistakes. Squash each one before May.

Russia is a **parliamentary** system! (Nope.)



01 State vs nation

A state is a political unit with sovereignty; a nation is a group sharing identity. They don't always match.

02 Legitimacy vs power

Legitimacy is acceptance of the right to rule; a regime can have power without legitimacy.

03 Wrong executive type

UK: parliamentary. Mexico and Nigeria: presidential. Russia: semi-presidential. Know each one.

04 Iran's two leaders

The Supreme Leader outranks the elected president and controls key institutions.

05 China's elections

China has local elections and a legislature, but the Communist Party controls candidates and decisions.

06 Federal vs unitary

Mexico, Nigeria and Russia are federal; the UK, China and Iran are unitary (the UK with devolution).

07 Vague comparisons

"Both countries have elections" isn't a comparison. Explain a specific similarity or difference and why it matters.

08 Ignoring the chart

In Q2, use the data shown. General knowledge alone won't earn the points.

09 Missing the response to the opposing view

The argument essay needs a counterargument and a rebuttal.

10 Out-of-date facts

Leaders and policies change. Focus on how institutions work, not who is in office.

Quick self-check: for each of the six countries, can you name its executive type, whether it is federal or unitary, and its electoral system for the legislature?

07

PLAN YOUR YEAR

Your study roadmap to May

A steady plan beats a last-minute rush. Build your six-country comparison grid as you go and update it every week.



Sep – Oct
Foundations



Unit 1 + UK and Mexico

Regimes, legitimacy and sovereignty. Start your comparison grid with the two democracies.

Nov – Dec
Institutions



Unit 2 + Nigeria and Russia **biggest unit**

Executives, legislatures and courts. Practice comparative analysis questions.

Jan – Feb
Citizens



Unit 3 + China and Iran

Political culture, civil society and social movements. Practice data questions.

Mar – Apr
Elections + change



Units 4–5

Electoral systems, parties, globalization and economic policy. Write timed argument essays.

Early May
Sharpen



Full timed sections

All four free-response types under timing. Review your comparison grid.

Exam day
May



AP Comp Gov exam • Bluebook

Sleep well, charge your device, and use the checklist at the end of this guide.

• The final four weeks

Week	Focus	Target
4 weeks out	Diagnose: 28 multiple-choice questions plus one argument essay	List your two weakest countries
3 weeks out	Fill gaps in your comparison grid	One fact per cell
2 weeks out	Full 2.5-hour practice exam	Finish both sections on time
Final week	Light review: vocabulary, grid, traps list	Rest the night before

08 TEST YOURSELF

10 practice questions

Original questions written by ACT SAT GO in the style of the exam, pitched at the harder end. Give yourself **13 minutes** for all ten, then check page 11.

1 UNIT 1 • LEGITIMACY

A government that bases its legitimacy mainly on economic growth and improving living standards is relying on:

- A rational-legal legitimacy through elections
- B traditional legitimacy
- C performance legitimacy
- D charismatic legitimacy

2 UNIT 2 • EXECUTIVES

Which country's executive structure is **semi-presidential**, with both a directly elected president and a prime minister?

- A United Kingdom
- B Mexico
- C Nigeria
- D Russia

3 UNIT 2 • IRAN

In Iran, which institution vets candidates for elected office?

- A The Guardian Council
- B The Assembly of Experts
- C The Majles (parliament)
- D The Expediency Council

4 UNIT 4 • ELECTORAL SYSTEMS

Compared with proportional representation, single-member district plurality systems tend to:

- A produce more parties in the legislature
- B favor two large parties and produce single-party majorities
- C guarantee seats in exact proportion to votes
- D require coalition governments

5 UNIT 1 • FEDERALISM

Nigeria adopted a federal system mainly to:

- A reduce the power of the military
- B copy the British system
- C increase oil exports
- D manage ethnic, religious and regional diversity

6 UNIT 3 • CIVIL SOCIETY

Which statement best describes civil society in China?

- A Independent groups operate freely and lobby the government
- B Many organizations exist but operate under close state supervision
- C There are no organizations outside the government
- D Civil society is protected by an independent judiciary

08 TEST YOURSELF (continued)

7 UNIT 5 • ECONOMIC CHANGE

Mexico's entry into NAFTA in 1994 is best described as an example of:

- A** import substitution industrialization
- B** nationalization of industry
- C** economic liberalization and integration into the global economy
- D** a planned command economy

8 UNIT 2 • JUDICIARY

Which country's highest court has the weakest power of judicial review over national legislation?

- A** United Kingdom
- B** Mexico
- C** Nigeria
- D** Russia (formally)

9 UNIT 4 • INTEREST GROUPS

A system in which the state recognizes a few official groups to represent labor and business is called:

- A** pluralism
- B** corporatism
- C** clientelism
- D** federalism

10 UNIT 3 • CLEAVAGES

Which is the best example of a cross-cutting cleavage?

- A** People of different religions share the same social class and support the same party
- B** Members of one ethnic group all share one religion and region
- C** A country with only one ethnic group
- D** Regional groups that never interact



CHECK YOUR WORK

Answer key & explanations

Read every explanation, even for questions you got right. Each one points to a pattern that keeps coming back on the exam.

#	Answer	Why
1		Performance legitimacy comes from delivering results, such as economic growth. The Chinese government relies heavily on it.
2	D • Russia	Russia has a powerful directly elected president and a prime minister. The UK is parliamentary; Mexico and Nigeria are presidential.
3		The Guardian Council (6 clerics, 6 jurists) vets candidates and can veto legislation that conflicts with Islamic law or the constitution.
4	B	Duverger's law: winner-take-all districts discourage small parties, tending to produce two-party systems and single-party majorities.
5		Federalism gives regions and states power, helping to manage deep ethnic and religious divisions in Nigeria.
6	B	Many NGOs operate in China, but they must register with and stay within limits set by the Communist Party.
7		Joining NAFTA lowered trade barriers and opened Mexico's economy, part of a wider shift away from protectionism.
8	A • UK	Because of parliamentary sovereignty, UK courts can't strike down acts of Parliament, though they can issue declarations of incompatibility.
9		Corporatism gives a few state-recognized groups privileged access. Pluralism allows many groups to compete freely.
10	A	Cross-cutting cleavages divide people in one way but unite them in another, which can reduce conflict.

9–10

Strong. Move on to full timed free-response practice.

6–8

On track. Revisit the unit behind every miss on page 4.

0–5

Build foundations now. Fill in a comparison grid for the six countries before anything else.

10 KNOW THE TARGET

How students score

In recent years, about 70–72% of students earned a 3 or higher on AP Comparative Government and Politics, and about 15–16% earned a 5. Steady preparation is what moves a score up a full point.

70–72%

of students earned a 3 or higher in recent years

15–16%

earned the top score of 5 in recent years

3+

is the score many colleges accept for credit or placement

What each AP score means

5

Extremely well qualified

4

Very well qualified

3

Qualified

2

Possibly qualified

1

No recommendation

Ranges reflect recent College Board score distributions and shift a little each year. Credit and placement policies vary by college, so check each college's AP policy.

Exam-day checklist

- ☐ **Bluebook** is installed and updated, and your device passed the exam check
- ☐ Device **fully charged**, with the charger packed
- ☐ Admission ticket and photo ID, as your school requires
- ☐ Confirm your **exam day and start time** in May with your AP coordinator
- ☐ Plan your time: about **1 min** per multiple-choice question; **10/20/20/40 min** for the four free-response questions
- ☐ Answer **every** multiple-choice question. Wrong answers don't lose points
- ☐ Review your **six-country comparison grid**
- ☐ Practice typing a full argument essay in 40 minutes

In the free-response section: define concepts precisely, use specific facts for each country, quote data from charts, and include a response to an opposing view in your argument essay.



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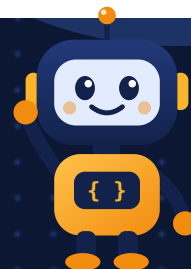
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Concept tutoring

Live 1-on-1 sessions on all five units and the six core countries.

Free-response coaching

Practice all four question types and get feedback against rubric-style criteria.

Timed exam practice

Full-length multiple-choice sets with score reports, so you see progress before May.

◆ Contact us

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